PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

(HANSARD)

FIFTH SERIES—VOLUME 484

HOUSE OF COMMONS

OFFICIAL REPORT

SECOND SESSION OF THE THIRTY-NINTH PARLIAMENT
OF THE UNITED KINGDOM OF GREAT BRITAIN
AND NORTHERN IRELAND
14 GEORGE VI

SESSION 1950—51

THIS VOLUME MAY BE CITED AS 484 H.C. DEB 5s.

COMPRISING PERIOD FROM
12th FEBRUARY—2nd MARCH, 1951

LONDON
HIS MAJESTY'S STATIONERY OFFICE
1951

PRICE 12*s.* 6*d.* NET

ORDERS OF THE DAY

CONSOLIDATED FUND BILL

Read a Second time.

Committed to a Committee of the whole House.

Committee Tomorrow.

FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Motion made, and Question proposed, "That this House do now adjourn."—[*Mr. Whiteley.*]

3.49 p.m.

Mr. Eden (Warwick and Leamington): It is unfortunately not only in the matter of headgear during a Division that there is some confusion in the world at the present time. Most hon. Members in all parts of the House will agree that there is much confusion in the public mind about the international situation, as also about certain aspects of the Government's policy to deal with it. We can understand that the Government have been grieviously handicapped in recent weeks by the Foreign Secretary's illness. We all most deeply deplore this, and join in wishing the right hon. Gentleman a speedy and complete recovery.

At the same time, it would be idle to deny that his illness and the silence of his colleagues, whether voluntary or imposed, has left the country sorely lacking any guidance at a time when direction and explanation are both equally necessary. The result has been that there have been a multitude of unofficial counsellors from Bristol, West, to Coventry, East, and they interpret and put a gloss on whatever hitherto has been the declared policy of the Government, thereby creating a general impression of order, counter order and disorder.

It is quite true that at the weekend we had a momentary gleam of comfort. I learn on the authority of the political correspondent of the "Observer" that at a private meeting of the Labour Party, the Lord President of the Council surpassed himself. I read:

> "Never had he made so brilliant a speech."

I felt encouraged. I thought that in the concluding phases of this debate we, too, would be given the enjoyment of that glittering performance. Alas, I learn it is not to be. Such treats are not for you, Mr. Speaker, nor for me. You and I are "the lesser breeds without the law." Only within the sacred precincts of the Labour Party conference is the foreign policy of the Labour Party described. That is just too bad, because there is nothing you and I, Mr. Speaker, can do about it. [An HON. MEMBER: "Join the Labour Party."] I thought that one hon. Member at least might suggest desperate measures, but let me assure him that we are not yet a suicide squad.

For myself I have neither the authority nor, I might add, the inclination to interpret the Government's policy. I shall try this afternoon to set out the main features of the international situation as they appear to us in the Opposition, and to lay down the courses which we would recommend. Since we last discussed foreign affairs two outstanding events have taken place in the international sphere—General Eisenhower's tour of Western Europe and his report to Congress; and the resolution passed by the United Nations condemning Chinese aggression in China, but setting up a Good Offices Committee for further negotiation should the opportunity arise.

This afternoon I propose to speak first of the West, and I think we cannot better open our proceedings than by paying a tribute, in which I feel the whole House or almost the whole House will wish to join, to General Eisenhower for the disinterested sense of duty which has led him once again to take so responsible a charge upon his broad shoulders. He has done much to invigorate these preparations for joint defence which are the declared policy of the Atlantic Powers. We have been equally glad to know of the visit of the French Prime Minister to Washington, which has clearly had good results for Franco-American relations. A closer understanding between our two friends must also be good news for us.

As we look at our problems in the West, Germany remains the dominant theme. I must confess that the answers of the Under-Secretary of State for Foreign Affairs in the House last week created in my mind, and I think in the minds of others abroad as well as at home, some uncertainty as to what the Government's policy really is. I hope I may be reassured, but, of course, this is not the first time that the party opposite have

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appeared confused on this particular issue. The House will remember that in October last, Mr. Morgan Phillips, Secretary of the Labour Party, spoke at the International Socialist Conference in Paris, and he said then that neither the British Government nor the British Labour Party had yet made up their minds on the problem of German re-armament.

That immediately brought a correction in a form of a Foreign Office statement, of which I would remind the House. The Foreign Office statement was:

"The British Government's attitude was made clear to the other Governments concerned during the meeting of the North Atlantic Treaty Council in New York and has not changed. They considered"—

that is His Majesty's Government—

"that Germany should be able to make an appropriate contribution to building up the defence of Western Europe."

I should like to know whether that correction is still the policy of His Majesty's Government or not, because whatever our views—and there is the possibility of holding varied views on this extremely difficult question—as to the policy to be pursued in this difficult German situation, to blow hot and cold is surely the most fatal of all.

Let us have a look to see what are our commitments, at least as I understand them, up to the present. If I am wrong in any particular, the Prime Minister will tell us. The first, most important of all, is that we have signed the Atlantic Pact. We stand by that agreement, and we have to build up the defence of the West to make it a reality. I do not think that that is disputed. The Foreign Secretary with his colleagues of the North Atlantic Council decided in New York on 26th September to invite a German contribution to Western defence. The Foreign Secretary gave us his reasons for this in the House last November. I think I should quote it to the House, because it is very important that we should know exactly where we are. This is what the Foreign Secretary said last November

"At the same time, the United States raised the question of a German contribution. On this point, too, His Majesty's Government were in agreement with the United States Government. If, unhappily, aggression were to take place in Europe, we are satisfied that its defence would have to take place as far East as possible, and that means that Western Germany must be involved; and if Western Germany is to be defended, it seems to us only fair and reasonable that the people of Western Germany should help in their own defence."—[OFFICIAL REPORT, 29th November, 1950; Vol. 481, c. 1172.]

I want to know are we still there. Is that still the Government's position?

It is true that immediately after that difficulties and differences arose. They did not arise about the principle of Germany making a contribution. They arose mainly over the French proposals for a European Army, and the Minister of Defence will remember this, because of the efforts he made at Washington during the conversations there last November. The Ministers of Defence did not, despite that, reach a conclusion on the form that the German contribution should take. Does our position remain the same? Do we still wish for German participation?

In December the Foreign Secretaries met again in Brussels and made a further attempt. According to the communiqué,

"unanimous agreement was reached on the question of a German contribution to Western defence, and that conversations should proceed between the High Commissioners and the German Federal Government."

Those conversations are going on at Petersberg at this present time, to try to give effect to this agreement. I should like to be told whether the Government still adhere to their decision taken in Brussels last December, and whether it is their wish and their endeavour to try to bring about a successful conclusion to the agreement they have entered into. That is what we should like to be told now, because, frankly, the Under-Secretary's reply seemed to us to leave that point very much in doubt.

Parallel with all this development there is the question of conversations with Russia, in which Germany would certainly be a main theme. I have always believed that if the Soviets were prepared to take part in discussions which gave even modest hopes of relieving the tension, which is not confined to Germany alone, we ought to make the attempt. Admittedly, it is not the slightest use going back to the kind of slanging match as has taken place at previous Foreign Secretaries' Conferences. Therefore, it has always seemed to me—I put this point to the House last autumn—that we ought to try to draw up an

agenda for this meeting with the Soviets, which is wider than covering Germany alone. Although there is much which is obscure in the last Soviet answer, they have not refused to draw up an agenda, and I think we should try to proceed with this now.

There are some things we have to note while we are doing it. We have to note first of all that the Soviet satellite forces of the East are continuing to grow in strength while notes of protest are hurled at us for the relatively most modest defensive preparations that we are making. It is in this connection that I want to present certain facts, which I think will not be challenged anywhere, and which we ought to have in mind if we are going into these conversations. Soviet Russia has in Eastern Germany forces which are overwhelmingly superior to our own. I contend that it is Soviet Russia which has taken the initiative in German rearmament. Let that be remembered, although it is very seldom stated. She has armed the Germans in the organisation called the *Bereitschaften*, a force, I think, of some 50,000. Part of the force is said to be heavily armed.

Over and above that, the satellite countries are, we believe, extending their armaments very rapidly. That includes the defeated enemy Powers whose forces surpass by far the limits allowed by the peace treaties which were only recently signed by the Soviet Union, with us, the United States and France. Let us look at the figures. These were given by Marshal Tito, but if the Government have other figures I hope they will give them to us. Take Roumania. The treaty allowed a force of 138,000 men. I believe she now has 300,000 under arms. Take Bulgaria. The treaty laid down 65,000. I think she has about 195,000 under arms. For Hungary, the treaty limit is 70,000. She has 165,000 under arms. If there is to be a discussion among the four Powers—I have indicated that I hope we shall draw up this agenda—clearly one of the first requirements which we have a right and a duty to make is that the armaments of the ex-enemy satellites should be reduced to the level already agreed in the treaties recently signed and now departed from.

The Government also have a responsibility—I realise that this is a grave matter and I approach it with some hesitation—to consider their position in respect of the increased threat which these forces constitute to Yugoslavia. I suggest that here is a subject for consultation with our French and United States Allies, and of course with our Commonwealth partners. I do not ask that the Government should reply on this topic if they find it embarrassing to do so, but I think that I should put to the House what I personally feel about it. If, as a result of the examination, we are agreed that we are not prepared to allow Yugoslavia to be made the victim of aggression by what I might describe as a Balkan-Korean process, we should do well, and we should make our best contribution to peace, if we expressed ourselves jointly and clearly on this topic soon. I believe that the whole course of international experience teaches us that we best serve peace by warning any would-be aggressors of the consequences of their acts before they make them.

To continue this examination of the possible items on the agenda of the Four-Power discussions, I think that we are also entitled to draw attention to the German forces already existing in the Eastern zone, such as the *Bereitschaften* which I have already mentioned. For the purpose of establishing this fact, and also of meeting the constant Soviet charges about alleged German forces already existing in the West, I have several times suggested that a Four-Power commission of investigation should be offered. I see no reason why this should not still take place. In all the miasma of propaganda that Moscow churns out there is this element of fact: Moscow knows very well the value of encouraging a fear of German re-armament as a means of binding these satellites, particularly in Prague and Warsaw, closer to it. That attempt is being made to persuade those countries to believe that German re-armament in the Western zone has already proceeded far. That could be examined.

Incidentally, if anyone doubts the determination of the Kremlin to maintain its hold on those countries, let him observe the wide arrests in Czechslovakia even while the Czech note supporting the Russian call for talks was being delivered to our Ambassador. Certainly, all is not well with the Communist Parties East of the Iron Curtain. It is rather a disturbing reflection that the slight modification, if we can call it "slight," in the Soviet attitude towards the meeting with the

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Western Powers has taken place only since agreement was reached to invite German co-operation in the defence of the West.

Yet, long ago, the Soviet Government could easily have obtained agreement on a 40-year treaty with Britain, France and the United States, against any revival of German military power such as was offered by the Americans in 1946, with our own and French support. It was turned down, and ever since, the Soviets have maintained their own armaments, and they have built up their satellites' military strength in the East on an overwhelming scale.

What is the purpose of all this rearmament? It is alleged to be directed against Germany. That is not true, for we all know that Western Germany has no military power at all. The truth is that all the measures increasing international tension of which we—I mean the British Government—are constantly accused, including the increase of our own Forces, have long ago been taken by the Soviets themselves. The Soviets never disarmed. They have intensified their threats against anybody who did not agree with them, like Yugoslavia, and when the West takes modest steps to increase its limited strength they accuse the West of aggressive designs.

This brings me to the most difficult question which we have to consider this afternoon, that of Western defence and the part that Germany should play therein. How are we to deal with this matter? It is very difficult for anyone of my generation, I admit, to be impartial and dispassionate about Germany. It is true, I think, that Englishmen are not good haters, but we have some memories, and for those of us whose first adult experience was the First War and for whom the Second is still a fresh memory, it is not a very easy task to be unprejudiced. Yet, is it not true that if we are to build for the future it is on the future that we have to concentrate our efforts? Nobody can ask us to forget but we can be asked to base our judgment on a just appraisal of realities present and future.

It seems to me, therefore, that we must make up our minds whether we want to do everything in our power to make it possible for Germany, if Germany be willing, to play her part in European affairs on fair and honourable terms. That is the decision of principle which we have to take. Re-armament is relatively secondary to it. Surely we must seek to do that, because unless Germany plays her part in all spheres of co-operation, not only the military, there can never be an enduring sense of security for Europe or for the German people either. This problem, it is interesting to recall, would have been there in some form even if our relations with Soviet Russia had been cordial. If this is our judgment, the sooner we take the necessary steps to give Germany a sense of equal status the better.

Mr. Sydney Silverman (Nelson and Colne): East Germany?

Mr. Eden: I am talking of the Germany that we can control. East Germany is under the control of another power. If anyone wishes to discover how far East Germany is under that control, they have only to look at recent statements about the acceptance of the Oder-Neisse frontier.

All the same, the final decision does not rest with us; it rests with Germany. If we and our former Allies are ready to play our part, Germany must play hers. It takes two to make a partnership, but it is partnership that we want and not hard bargaining over points which inevitably lose their value with the mere passage of time. It has always been difficult to interpret public opinion in a country like Germany where the tradition of Parliamentary discussion and political controversy, as we have it here in full measure these days, has never been strong or deep in the national character. But I was struck when I was recently in Germany by what appeared to be a strongly held view that, if Germany is to play her part in Western defence, that part should be played not by revival of a German National Army but within a European Army as a means of assuring the security and peace of Europe. That seems to me to be very important. Admittedly, it is very difficult to know how deep this feeling goes in Germany.

Mr. Bellenger (Bassetlaw): In view of the discussion to follow, it would be very interesting if the right hon. Gentleman would elaborate what he learnt in

Germany about what the Germans and others mean when they speak of taking part in European forces.

Mr. Eden: I shall explain that as best I can if the right hon. Gentleman will be patient. I was saying that it is difficult to know how deep this feeling goes and how genuine it is. It is surely—I believe the whole House will agree—a remarkable factor that there are, anyhow, German leaders today who wish to see their country's effort integrated with that of the European neighbours and that there are French leaders who wish the same thing to happen. Perhaps that seems more important to me than it does to some other hon. Members. When I recall how Franco-German quarrels have overlain the whole international scene for generations, it seems to me that here is an opportunity that we should surely grasp if it is really there.

Let us have a look to see if it is there and consider what we mean by "European Army." The best definition of this that I know is one given by my right hon. Friend the Member for Woodford (Mr. Churchill) some months ago. He said that what we want to bring about is:

". . . an Atlantic army with . . . a European army inside of it and a German contingent, on honourable terms, inside that."—[OFFICIAL REPORT, 30th November, 1950; Vol. 481, c. 1333.]

To carry the argument a little further, this European Army would, of course, form part of General Eisenhower's Atlantic Force. French, Belgian and German units would be represented in it, and maybe others also. I should hope that we would be there.

I do not suggest that the whole of our defence effort on the Continent should be in the European Army, but to me it seems that there is here a unique opportunity for which we may never forgive ourselves if we miss it. It might be—I would ask hon. Members not to dismiss this derisorily—that this force would gradually grow in authority with the respect it enjoyed so that it was able to give Europe a new sense of unity and confidence. How invaluable that could be today and in the years that lie ahead.

I understand that the representatives of France, Italy, Belgium and the Netherlands are meeting in Paris—I believe it will be in the next few days—to discuss this project. It has many technical problems, which the right hon. Gentleman no doubt has in mind. We are to be represented there, I understand, by our Ambassador, but only as an observer. I would beg the Government, even at this late hour, to reconsider their decision and to send a delegate to this Conference who will make constructive suggestions and try to meet the technical difficulties in a spirit of a real desire to see a European Force established.

It seems to me that there are really, broadly, only two policies for Germany. One is to try gradually to bring Germany into closer co-operation with the West. That is surely our policy—that of both sides of the House—politically and economically. If that is to be followed, then it is bound sooner or later to find some expression in the sphere of defence. It is absolutely inescapable, as it was before. Would it not be immensely advantageous to peace if that German contribution could find expression in a European Army where French, Belgians, Dutch and British would serve side by side.

Mr. Emrys Hughes (Ayrshire, South): And an air force too?

Mr. Eden: It is contemplated that they should make contributions.

Mr. Emrys Hughes: Would the right hon. Gentleman make this clear? Is he arguing in favour of Germany having an air force again?

Mr. Eden: I was arguing that she should have certain contingents integrated in the European Army and tactical Air Force. That does not necessarily mean that she would have the right to construct aeroplanes in Germany. That is another matter to be considered.

Mr. Emrys Hughes: And a navy?

Mr. Eden: Not for this purpose at any rate. One does not need a navy to operate an army in Europe. All I am saying at this moment is that the House should consider this as a serious project which offers us a way out of our difficulties if we are seeking a way out and if our policy is still to bring Western Germany into our defensive system.

That is one policy. There is another. The only other that I can see appears to be the Soviet policy, which, so far as I understand it, would propose the demilitarisation and the neutralisation of

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Germany. That does not seem to me to be practicable or desirable as a final solution, nor, I am pretty sure, is it intended to be a final solution by Soviet Russia either. In the Soviet mind I have not the least doubt that it is merely a phase preceding a Communist attempt to seize power in that country as it has done in others before. I am not in the least reassured when I am told, as I am frequently, that in a neutralised and demilitarised Germany, from which all the Allied Forces have been withdrawn, the majority of the population will be non-Communist. Of course they will. So they were in Czechoslovakia, and how much did that avail them there? The interesting thing is that there has never yet been an occasion anywhere in the world where a Communist Government has come into power under a free vote of the people. But they would not have to worry about that in Germany any more than they have done anywhere else.

Those are the only two policies it seems to me, and I prefer the one, in the difficult choice we have to make, which I understood the Government were pursuing—I hope they are pursuing it—in an endeavour to align ever more closely the people of Western Germany with the free democracies.

I must delay the House for a few moments more to make some observations on the Far East. I will not go over a lot of wearisome ground that has been covered before, but we might do well to remind ourselves this afternoon of that first debate we had on Korea last July—do hon. Members recall it?—and to refresh our memories about the spirit in which we then approached the act of aggression in that country. At that time virtually the whole House gave its overwhelming support to the Government's Motion. Do hon. Members remember the terms of that Motion?—

> "That this House fully supports the action taken by His Majesty's Government in conformity with their obligations under the United Nations Charter in helping to resist the unprovoked aggression against the Republic of Korea."

That is where we were then. Speaker after speaker rose from the benches opposite and endorsed the fundamental points: that North Korea had committed an act of aggression; that the United Nations had a responsibility to assist the victim; and that the act of aggression would never have taken place unless Soviet Russia had made it possible. All that and much more was said. I will quote from only one speech out of the many from which I could quote, that of the hon. Member for Shettleston (Mr. McGovern), who was full of praise that the United States went in so speedily to take the burden of the United Nations. He said:

> "I honour America for going in speedily, because one of the great complaints in this country hitherto has been that America was too keen on keeping out and furnishing the weapons for other people to fight with. . . . The United States, this country and the United Nations cannot afford to fail in this situation." —[OFFICIAL REPORT, 5th July, 1950; Vol 477, c. 487 and 536.]

And there were many speeches by other hon. Members in the same vein.

Mr. Emrys Hughes: Does the right hon. Gentleman accept the hon. Member for Shettleston (Mr. McGovern) as an authority?

Mr. Eden: I think I prefer him to the hon. Member for Ayrshire, South (Mr. Emrys Hughes), but I hope I shall not be faced with that embarrassing alternative.

The truth is that there would never have been a Korean partition at all if Soviet Russia had not consistently refused to allow the United Nations Commission to function in the whole of Korea. When I read some of the remarks about that Commission, I might almost think it was some sinister plot created by the United States Government. But so far from it being an American conspiracy, I have not been able to find that there was an American on the Commission. There was an Indian—that ought to be all right—there was a Syrian—that should not be wrong—there was an Australian and a Canadian—nobody could object to them. There was not an American.

It was this Commission which supervised the elections in South Korea—now so vehemently denounced in some weekly papers—that established the Government which was afterwards recognised by the majority of the United Nations. All I have to say about all that is that whether we like the political colour of that Government or not is completely irrelevant. What is a

fact is that it was freely elected by the South Koreans as their Government. We may deplore their judgment; but at least the North Koreans had no chance to make a decision.

A great deal of confusion also seems to exist about the events which led to the crossing of the 38th parallel. I thought that the Foreign Secretary was fair and frank on that point during the last debate. But still statements are made —one continually reads them—as though General MacArthur himself was to blame for going beyond the 38th parallel. That is not true, I submit. We dealt with it in our last debate, when the Foreign Secretary endorsed my submission that the decision to go beyond the parallel was taken by the United Nations. As we all know, General MacArthur held his troops on the parallel from 1st to 9th October. It was on 7th October that the Assembly passed the resolution which implicitly agreed that we had a right to go beyond the 38th parallel.

Mr. S. Silverman: What jurisdiction had it to do that?

Mr. Eden: The Assembly?

Mr. Silverman: Yes. What is there in the Charter which justified the Assembly in authorising not merely the resistance to and the defeat of the aggression that had taken place, but in going further than that, with the purely political object of unifying Korea?

Mr. Eden: The only argument that could be used, if it is an argument, against the United Nations proceeding with the action which it did proceed with is that a full membership was not present. But there is nothing whatever in the Charter, so far as my memory serves me, which prevents the rest of the United Nations from acting if certain members choose to stay away.

Mr. Silverman: I was not dealing with that.

Mr. Eden: Certainly, if the United Nations could not function because there was some absentee, it would be the easiest thing in the world for some member to stay away and hamstring all the United Nations.

Mr. Silverman: I am afraid that the right hon. Gentleman has missed my point. I was not basing my argument, for the moment, on the constitution of the Security Council but on the difference between United Nations armed action to resist aggression when it takes place and United Nations armed action to carry out the purely political object of unifying a divided country. If that is really within the United Nations Charter, would there be anything to prevent them from unifying Ireland in the same way?

Mr. Eden: Yes, I think there would, because in this particular case, as the hon. Gentleman knows very well, it was only the unilateral action of Soviet Russia which divided Korea. The United Nations have never recognised the Parallel. In their eyes Korea is still one, as the Foreign Secretary said the other day; and as in our eyes it was one when we first approached this problem.

Mr. Silverman: Then how could there be aggression?

Mr. Eden: The aggression does not lie in that, but in the military force applied against the people of South Korea.

Mr. Silverman: I hope the right hon. Gentleman will assist me, because I confess I have had considerable difficulty about it. I understand the argument that we are entitled to go beyond the frontier of the 38th parallel because it was never a juridical or political frontier. That is quite a clear argument. But if it is true, then North Korea was never a State and if North Korea was never a State, how could it be guilty of aggression?

Mr. Eden: I am glad I gave way to the hon. Gentleman. If on a later occasion this country—which God forbid—were ever the victim of aggression, and that kind of argument was all that could be raised to prevent others from coming to our help, it would be a sad day indeed for Britain and the world.

Mr. Silverman: The right hon. Gentleman will remember that I was in favour of the United Nations going to the assistance of Korea. I am in favour of it still on the basis that there was an attack by North Korea, being a State, upon South Korea, being another. I think that was right. I am glad we did and I am glad we succeeded. But, having said that, we destroy any argument that the 38th parallel was not a frontier; and we were wrong to go beyond it.

Mr. Eden: I can only say how pleased I am to learn—I did not know it—that the hon. Gentleman was glad of the success of the action against the North Korean Government. I hope he will express it in a more convincing fashion in the speech he will make later today. I had always fallen under the impression that the difference between the hon. Gentleman and Mr. Cole was almost indistinguishable. I think I have been extremely patient here; these have been the most hair-splitting and logic-chopping arguments I have ever heard.

What about the present position in Korea, and what ought we to do there now? Evidently the military situation has much improved and the greatest credit is due to General Ridgeway, who has clearly inspired his command in a remarkable manner. Since the whole purpose of the United Nations intervention in Korea was to prove that aggression does not pay—we are all agreed about that, thank goodness—and to unify the country, there seems to me a better chance of doing both these things now than there was two or three months ago. Our duty, therefore, clearly is to hold on and to continue our military endeavour until such time as the aggressors are willing to negotiate on a basis which takes account of international obligations.

I will say a word about the problem of Formosa, for I do not wish to be accused of evading difficulties.

Mr. Harold Davies (Leek): And the re-armament of Japan.

Mr. Eden: I have nothing to say about Japan, except that I am not personally sponsoring the re-armament of Japan, if that is any comfort to the hon. Gentleman. I am dealing with Formosa. It seems to me that the best contribution I have read to this difficult topic was in the form of a letter in "The Times" from Professor Gilbert Murray, a much more respected authority on these matters than I am. It appeared the other day and I will quote it. He says it is over-simplifying

> "a complicated problem in claiming that the new China, as soon as she agrees not to pursue aggression further, retains all the rights and privileges that 'China' possessed before the aggression? 'China,' for example, has a right to Formosa. But does that mean that the new mainland 'China' has an indefeasible right, irrespective of the wishes of the inhabitants, to take possession of Formosa by force, and even to demand United Nations help in doing so? These are difficult problems."

They are indeed. It seems clear to me that they are not capable of any swift and sudden solution; and here, surely, is an issue which must form part of the general peace settlement in the Far East. In the meanwhile, it is right to recall that the future of Formosa is, in fact, linked with the question of a treaty with Japan. Here I must ask the Prime Minister a question. Are the Government fully informed as to the conversations which Mr. Dulles has been having in Japan? I do not think we take exception to the conversations if, as I understand, they are exploratory in character. But I should like to know about them, and I am sure the House would. We are also happy to learn that Mr. Dulles is to proceed at once to Australia and New Zealand.

That brings me to my real concern about our future relations with Japan. In my view it is essential that, if a treaty is to be made with Japan, its terms should be agreed and jointly signed at least by those free nations of the British Commonwealth and our allies who fought the war against Japan from the beginning and who are today working together in the East as in the West. I hope there will not be any individual signatures amongst them of an individual treaty: they ought to be done together.

In Indo-China we have all noticed with encouragement the notable successes which have recently been won by the French Union Forces. General de Lattre de Tassigny has clearly renewed the confidence of the joint forces there in what is still a highly critical situation.

These are my final words. All these events emphasise the imperative need for political directives. Without these, military integration—and we are doing it now—can never have its full effect. This is particularly true when we are dealing, as we are now dealing, with a world front. It appears that quite good results have come from the Franco-American discussions in Washington. That is all to the good. But we still need some machinery at the highest level which will provide political co-ordination and guide the military effort.

I know how difficult that is. Two months ago the Prime Minister visited

the United States. We welcomed that visit. In fact, I think we played a part in suggesting it. Can the heads of States or Governments or the Foreign Secretaries meet at regular intervals for the express purpose of giving political directives for military preparations? It is difficult to escape an impression that, while the work of military co-ordination goes ahead reasonably well on a regional basis, that of central political direction is lagging. Germany is an example of that.

I described earlier what I called two alternative policies on Germany. There may be others. But clearly we and the other Powers who are principally concerned, especially France and the United States, must agree our line and hold to it here and elsewhere. Otherwise what are we going to see? We are going to see the contrast of a fixed aim pursued with relentless determination by central Communist direction as against our uncertain and indeterminate variations of policy, which too often appear to take the place of decisions unanimously reached and firmly applied.

I admit the difficulties and I tell the Prime Minister that I have no snap solution, but this at least is certain: political direction in a free democracy needs to be backed by an informed public opinion, and there cannot be that public opinion unless more continuous information and explanation is addressed to them by His Majesty's Ministers. All these elements are needed if the free nations are to build up an effective deterrent to aggression.

We in Europe have confirmed by the acid test of experience that the diplomacy of the peace-makers must have the backing of arms. I cannot see that there is any escape from it. The whole political strategy of the Soviet Union since the war has been governed by the knowledge of their overwhelmingly superior armed forces. Of course, Moscow has kept completely quiet about that, covering the maintenance of vast military preparations with a smokescreen of peace protestations. I do not think we shall get very far if we only protest our own lack of strength and hope thereby to stay Moscow's obviously expansionist spirit. I do not think that will work. Therefore, I feel that there is no escape from the stern necessity to increase our defensive strength. Only by such means in the world as it is unhappily today can we enable diplomacy to perform its essential function which, let me remind the House, is to avert war, instead of merely permitting a few to survive it.

4.38 p.m.

The Prime Minister (Mr. Attlee): I am sorry that my right hon. Friend the Foreign Secretary is not able to be here in the House today. He is getting over a serious illness; he is much better. He was getting stronger when, unhappily, this attack came upon him. I have, however, had the opportunity of discussing matters with him.

When we last had a Foreign Affairs discussion in the House in November I said, in concluding that two days' debate, that there had been revealed a very great measure of agreement. I hope we shall find that so today. The House is concerned, on all sides, with one major question—how to preserve peace and how to preserve our British way of life. The two go together, because peace without the kind of life we want would be no peace to us.

There is no break in the continuity of Government policy when my right hon. Friend is unhappily ill for two or three weeks, because we have been following a steady policy and a policy based on definite principles. Those principles were laid down five and a half years ago when we supported, under the leadership of the right hon. Member for Warwick and Leamington (Mr. Eden), at San Francisco, the principles of the United Nations and the basis of our policy was then, and is still now, support of the United Nations and acceptance of the obligations of membership. During these last five and a half years we have seen continued obstruction and lack of co-operation on the part of the U.S.S.R. and its satellites. Indeed, everything goes to show that the purpose of that Government has been not to promote peace, but to cause trouble everywhere in the world.

We have to face the grim facts of the situation. They maintain immense armaments, they carry on a hostile and subversive propaganda against all non-Communist States—indeed, against a Communist State such as Yugoslavia, if it does not take its orders exactly from the Kremlin. That is the reason why, in this country and other countries, we have